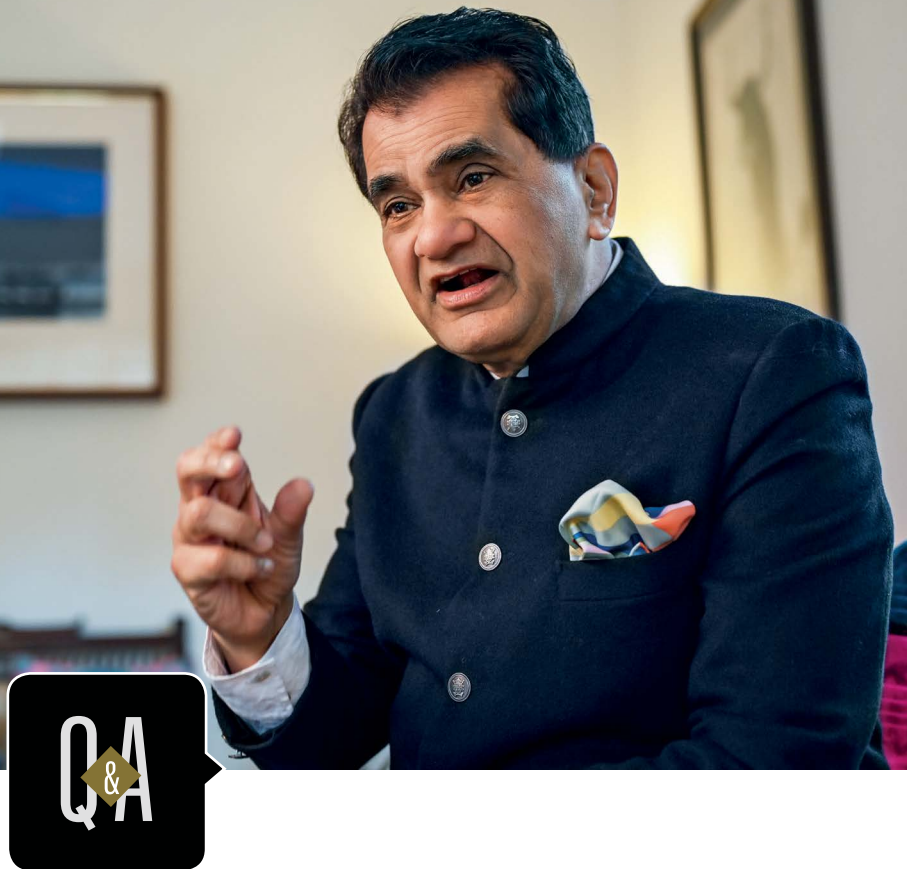




“INDIA’S GROWTH IS A FUNCTION OF THE GROWTH OF ITS STATES”

G20 Sherpa Amitabh Kant says that as a part of the G20 troika, India continues to work with Brazil to take forward its agenda

By **Surabhi** • PHOTOS BY **HARDIK CHHABRA**

INDIA’S G20 SHERPA

Amitabh Kant, 67, has won laurels for the way he handled the country’s G20 presidency as an ace negotiator. An expert policymaker with previous tenures as DIPP Secretary and NITI Aayog CEO, he has a finger on the pulse of the economy. In an interview with *Business Today*, he speaks about the further reforms that are needed and says states must take up initiatives on

sustainable urbanisation and ease of doing business. Edited excerpts:

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How do you plan to take forward India’s agenda during Brazil’s presidency of the G20?

We have had our discussions with Brazil. Most of the issues like women-led development and Sustainable Development Goals are being taken forward by Brazil

in a more invigorated manner. We are a member of the G20 troika, we work in partnership with Brazil, and we will take these issues vigorously forward with them.

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There are a number of geopolitical pressures, including the Russia-Ukraine war, the Israel-Hamas conflict, and the Red Sea crisis. How will the G20 take forward the

economic agenda in such a divided world?

There are challenges and we were lucky that the Israel-Palestine issue had not come up during India’s G20 Presidency... The Russia-Ukraine crisis was a major challenge for the whole year of India’s presidency. I think Brazil will have this challenge; we will have to work with them because eventually this is a geopolitical challenge. If you look at the world today, there are three severe challenges—the Israel-Palestine issue, the Russia-Ukraine crisis, and then there’s a separate economic challenge of China and the US on how the global economy needs to grow. In all these issues, one key factor will always be the US, and therefore, a lot will depend on how the American election shapes up.

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What is your view on the current economic prospects and challenges?

India is on the cusp of growth. It needs to sustain this growth over a three-decade period. We will be a very major driver of the global economy. By around the 2040s, one in every fourth working person in the world will be from India. Therefore, we need to skill our population... Skilling India will be a very critical driver of India’s growth story.